

Unit 2: Punctuation and Its Purpose

Punctuation marks are symbols we use in writing to make our meaning clear. Without punctuation, writing is confusing and hard to read.

The full stop. A full stop ends a sentence. It tells the reader that one complete thought has finished. The dog sat on the mat.

The question mark. A question mark ends a sentence that asks something. It replaces the full stop when a question is being asked. What is your name? Where do you live? How old are you?

The exclamation mark. An exclamation mark shows strong feeling. It can show surprise, excitement, or urgency. Watch out! I cannot believe it! What a wonderful day!

The comma. A comma shows a short pause inside a sentence. It is used to separate items in a list. I need a pen, a pencil, a ruler, and an eraser. A comma is also used before connecting words like but, and, and so when joining two sentences. I wanted to play outside, but it was raining.

Capital letters. Every sentence begins with a capital letter. The names of people and places also begin with capital letters. My name is Tendai. I live in Harare. We visited Victoria Falls.

Speech marks. Also called quotation marks. They show the exact words someone said. Tendai said, "I am ready to go." The teacher asked, "Did you finish your work?"

Punctuation makes writing clear and easy to understand. When you read aloud, punctuation tells you when to pause, stop, or change your voice. Pay attention to punctuation marks every time you read.